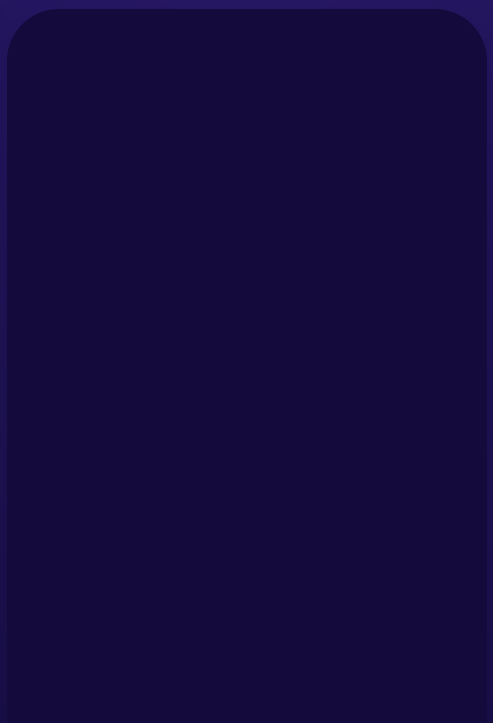
THE OFFICIAL GUIDE

BuscAR Hunt

The complete how-to for hosting, playing and building story-driven AR scavenger hunts.

For Players | For Hosts | For Builders



WELCOME

Turn any space into a story

BuscAR Hunt is a free iPhone app for co-located, story-driven scavenger hunts. Everyone gathers in one real place, joins the same game on their own phone, and races through **clues, puzzles and AR discoveries** toward a grand finale.

Players

Join with a 5-character code, follow clues around the space, scan station codes, tap glowing AR objects and solve puzzles. **Guests never need to buy anything or make an account.**

Hosts

Buy a ready-made hunt (like **The Hollow House**), set it up in your own home or venue (plan roughly 30–45 minutes the first time for an 11-station hunt), print the station cards, place the AR objects, and run the game.

Builders

Unlock the Builder once, then create your own hunts: your clues, your puzzles, your narrator, your AR objects and items. Host them as often as you like.

What's inside

Part	Chapter	Page
Start	The basics: what you need, how accounts and purchases work	3
Part 1	**Playing a hunt**: joining, stations, puzzles, satchel, journal, vault, winning	4–8
Part 2	**Hosting a ready-made hunt**: the story, the Store, host setup, print pack, AR placement, local clues, narration modes, lobby, monitor, ending a game	9–17
Part 3	**Building your own hunt**: builder walk-through, libraries and storage, all 11 puzzle types with samples, items, vault finale, narration writing	18–24
Part 4	**Tips, ideas and troubleshooting**: setup tricks, clue writing, game ideas, FAQ	25–28

NOTE Screens shown are from an iPhone running the app. Colors and wording may differ slightly between app updates.

3 roles

Every game has one **host** (sets up and starts the game) and any number of **players**. A host can also play, or watch from a monitor screen instead.

START HERE

The basics in five minutes

What you need

An iPhone
iOS 17 or newer. AR objects need a phone that supports ARKit (any recent iPhone).

Camera access
Used to scan station QR codes and to show AR objects. Allow it when asked.

An internet connection
Games are shared live between phones, so everyone needs Wi-Fi or mobile data.

Who needs what

I want to…	I need…
Join and play any game	The free app and a room code. No account, no purchase.
Host a ready-made hunt (e.g. The Hollow House)	Sign in with Apple **and** that hunt's one-time purchase from the Store tab.
Build and host my own hunts	Sign in with Apple **and** the one-time **Builder Unlock** purchase.

GOOD TO KNOW Purchases belong to your Apple ID. If you reinstall or get a new phone, tap **Restore purchases** (Store tab or Profile) to get them back.

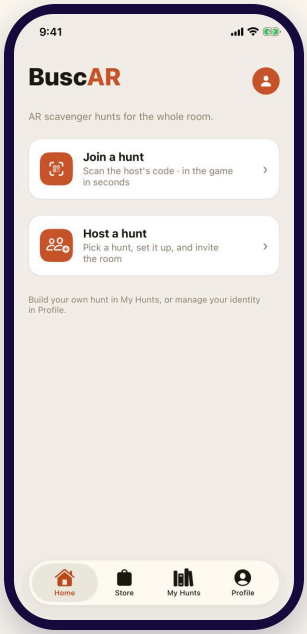
The four tabs

Home
Join a hunt, host a hunt, and resume a game in progress.

Store
Browse and buy ready-made hunts. Restore purchases here too.

My Hunts
Hunts you built, hunts you bought, hunts you joined, and your AR and item libraries.

Profile
Your display name, Sign in with Apple, Past hunts, restore purchases, sign out and delete account.



The Home tab with the tab bar along the bottom

Your first game, in one line

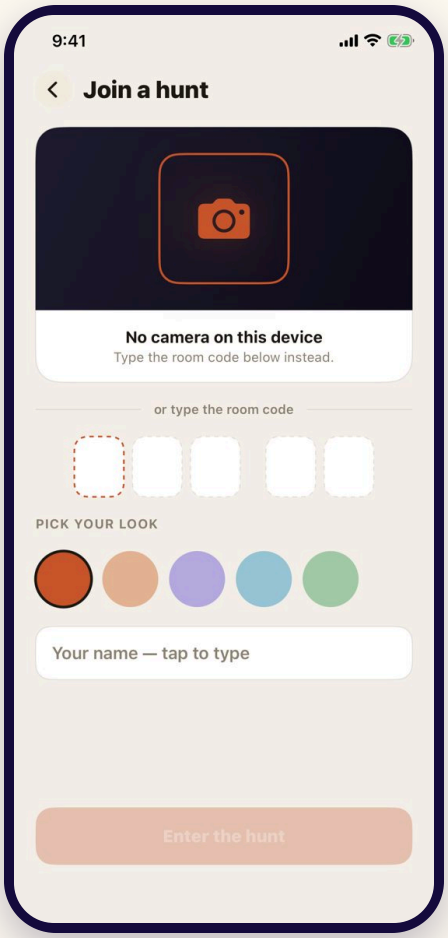
1 Join enter the code › **2 Read** the clue › **3 Walk** to the spot › **4 Scan** the QR card › **5 Solve** the puzzle

PART 1 · PLAYING

Joining a game

You only need the free app. Your host will show you a room code or a QR code on their phone (or a printed join poster on the wall).

1. **Tap "Join a hunt"** on the Home tab.
2. **Scan the host's QR code** with the camera box, or **type the 5-character room code** (3 letters + 2 numbers, like FOX-42). A successful scan joins automatically.
3. **Pick your look:** choose one of five colors for your player badge.
4. **Type your name.** The app remembers it for next time. You can change it any time in Profile.
5. Tap **Enter the hunt**. You land in the lobby: "Waiting for the host to start…"
6. When the host taps **Start**, everyone moves into the game at the same moment.



Join a hunt: scanner on top, code boxes below

TIP Joined late? You can still join after the game starts, up to the host's player limit. If you see "This room is full," ask your host to raise the limit.

NO CAMERA? If camera access is off, the code boxes work on their own. You can always type the code instead of scanning.

Lost your place? Rejoining

Closed the app or phone died

Reopen BuscAR Hunt. If your game is still running you are reconnected automatically, with your points, items and marks intact. The **Resume** card on Home also takes you back.

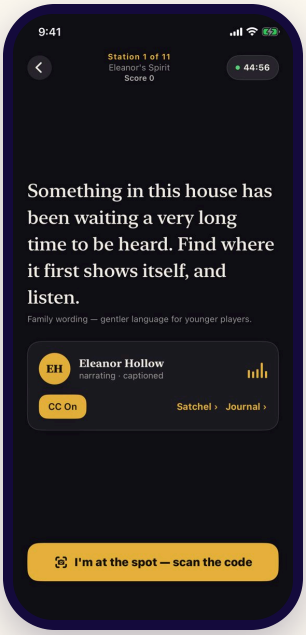
Your timer and score

The countdown comes from the host's shared clock, so time you spend away still counts. Your progress is saved to your player record after every station.

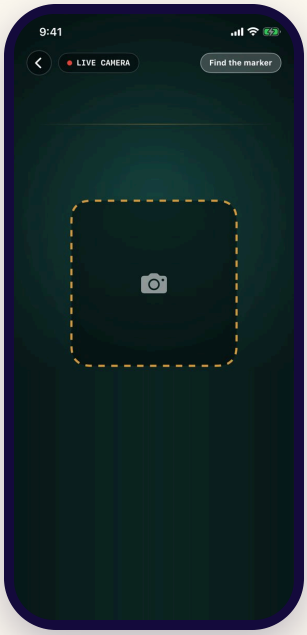
PART 1 · PLAYING

How a station works

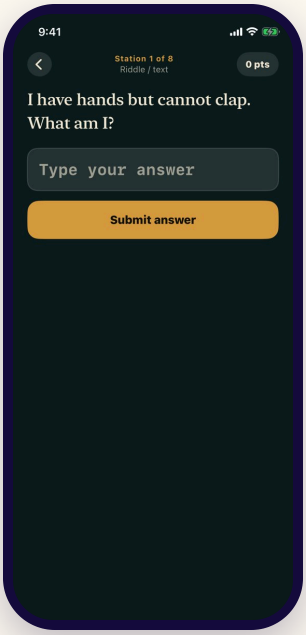
Every station follows the same four beats. Learn them once and you can play any hunt.



1 · Read the clue



2 · Scan the code



3 · Solve the puzzle

1 · The clue screen

Shows **Station N of M**, the shared countdown (if the host set one), and your score. Read the clue, then walk to the place it describes. The narrator card shows what the narrator says; tap **CC** to turn captions on or off, and use **Satchel** and **Journal** any time. If your host added a **"Proceed to"** line, it appears right under the clue.

2 · Scan the station code

Tap **"I'm at the spot — scan the code"** and point your camera at the printed QR card at that spot. A green check says **Arrived**. Wrong card? The app tells you which station it belongs to.

3 · The AR reveal

Keep the camera aimed at the station card. The hidden object appears in the host's exact spot. **Tap it** to open the puzzle. Pinch to resize and twist two fingers to rotate, for a better look. **Reset** puts it back. If the object hasn't appeared yet, keep the card in view and move the phone slowly.

4 · Solve the puzzle

Get it right to earn points, maybe an item for your satchel, and sometimes a **vault mark** (one digit of your secret code). A wrong answer just shakes the screen, and you can try again.

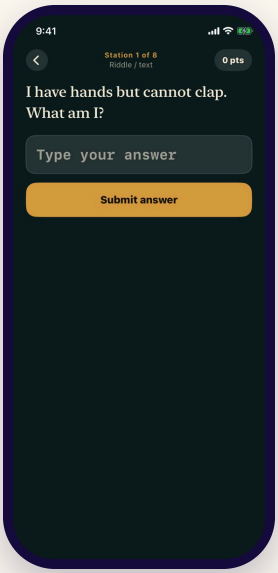
TIP Stand 1–2 steps back from the card so the whole QR code fits in view, and make sure there's light on it. Dim rooms are the number one cause of slow scans.

HEADS UP AR objects only appear on a real iPhone, not in the iOS Simulator. If AR is unavailable or camera permission is off, the app says so and explains how to fix it in Settings.

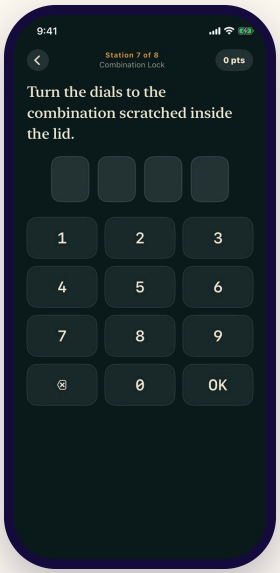
PART 1 · PLAYING

Meet the puzzles

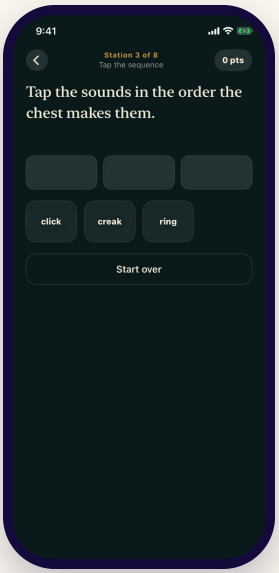
Eleven kinds of puzzle can appear. Here is how each one feels on your screen. There is no per-puzzle timer, and a wrong answer simply lets you try again.



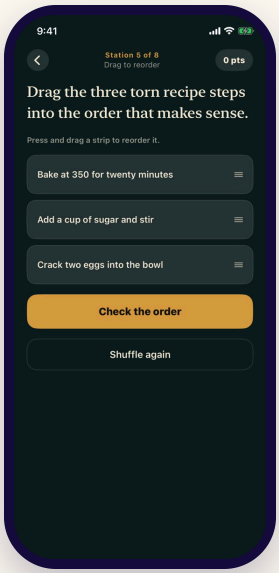
Riddle / Cipher
Type your answer, tap Submit.



Combination Lock / Dial
Punch in the digits, tap OK.



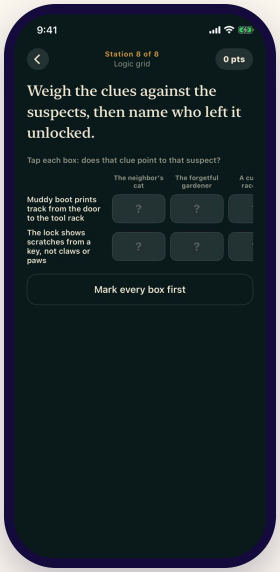
Tap the sequence
Tap the items in the right order.



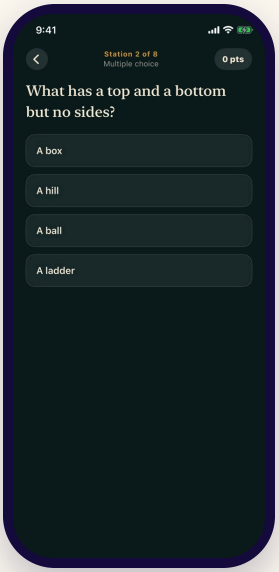
Drag to reorder
Drag strips until it reads true.



Tap to find
Tap the telling detail in the picture.



Logic grid
Mark clues against suspects, then accuse.



Multiple choice
Pick one answer. Order is shuffled per player.

Real-world ones

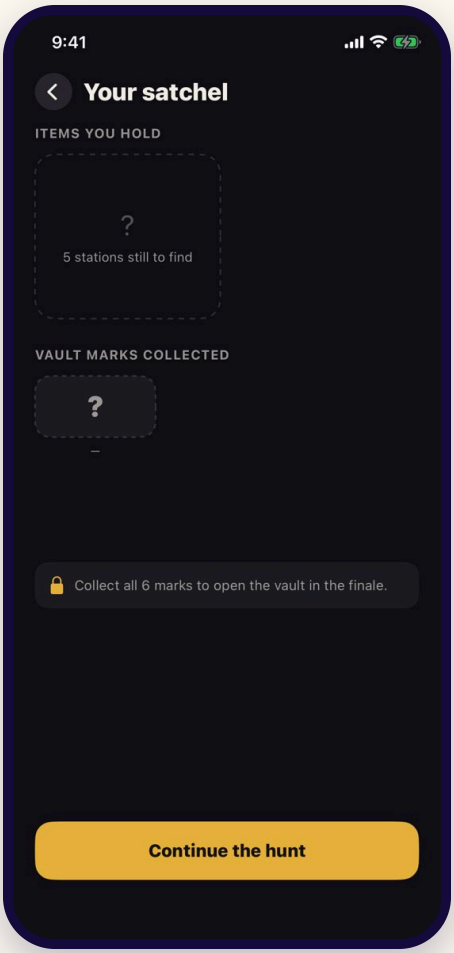
QR verify: the prompt sends you to scan a second QR code, then asks you to read something there. Tap Continue when done.

Physical prop + AR: find a real object (open a tin, read a card), follow the prompt, tap Continue.

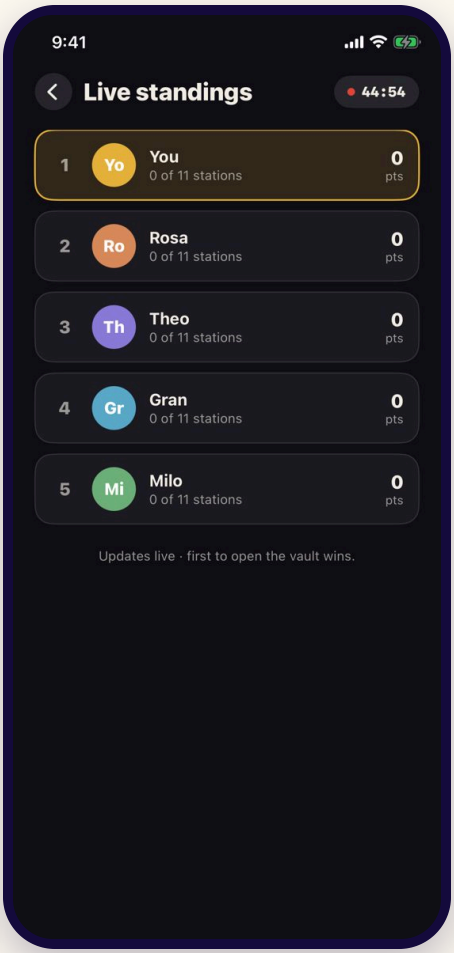
TIP Items and information carry forward. A number on a card at one station may be the answer at another, and the Journal keeps every line the narrator has said. **When stuck, check your Journal and Satchel.**

PART 1 · PLAYING

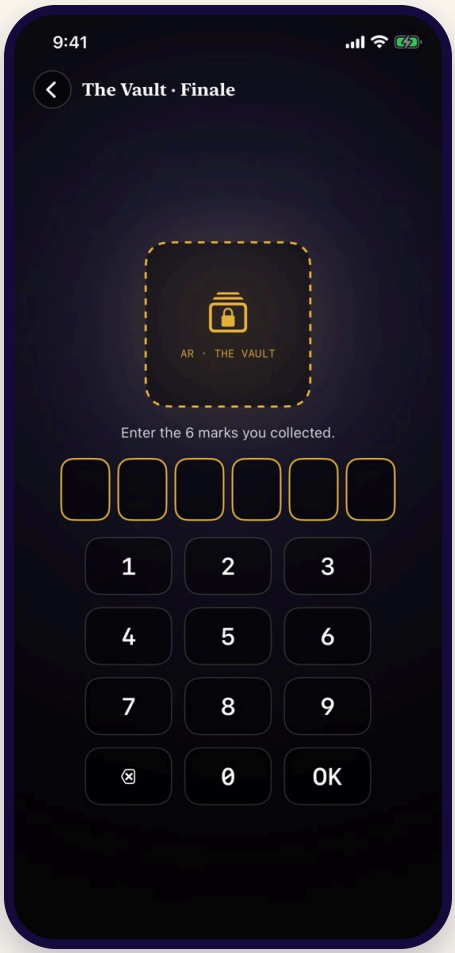
Your toolkit while you play



Satchel



Live standings



The vault

Satchel

Everything you are carrying, plus your **vault marks**. Tap an item for a bigger look and any inscription the author wrote on it. Reach it from the clue screen's **Satchel ›** button.

Journal

Every line the narrator has spoken, in order. Includes a **voice volume** slider and a replay for the last line. Tap **Journal ›** on the clue screen.

Family or Adult tone

The clue screen has a small **Family mode · switch** pill. Flip it any time and *only your phone* changes: clue wording, captions and narration shift between a gentler family tone and a darker adult one. Your Journal re-reads in the new tone. (More on page 15.)

Live standings

Everyone's points and stations completed, updating live. Tap the timer pill on the clue screen to open it. The timer is the same on every phone.

The vault finale

Some hunts end in an AR vault. As you solve certain stations you collect **marks**, each one digit of *your own* secret code. Nobody else's digits match yours, so shouting answers across the room won't help. At the end, enter all of your digits in **any order** to open it.

Accessibility

Captions on screen, replay-last-line, and an independent voice volume are built in from the start.

PART 1 · PLAYING

Winning, scoring and the recap

How a game ends depends on two choices your **host** makes before the game: the **win mode** and an optional **timer**.

Mode	Who wins?
Race	The first player to **finish the hunt** (last station, or opening the vault). The game ends for everyone at that moment.
Score	The player with the **most points**. Finishing first is not enough on its own. The game ends when everyone has finished, the timer runs out, or the host ends it.

With a timer

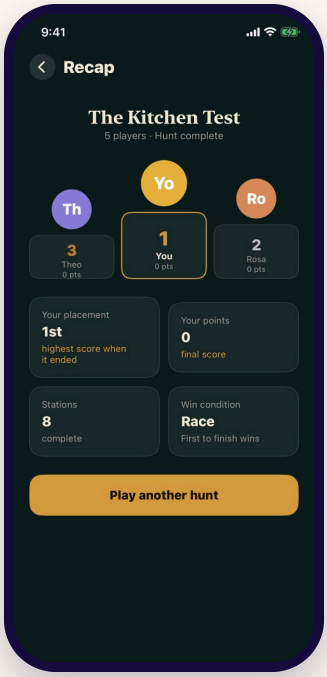
Race + timer: if the clock hits zero and nobody finished, the hunt ends with no winner ("time's up"). **Score + timer:** the points a station awards **shrink steadily as the clock runs down**, so speed matters. Score without a timer awards each station's full points.

Ties in Score mode

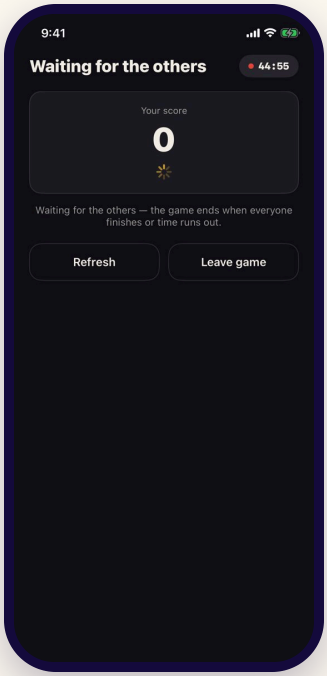
Most points wins. A tie is broken by more stations completed, then who finished earlier.

Finished, but others are still playing?

In Score mode you land on a **Waiting for the others** screen showing your score. It jumps to the recap by itself when the game ends. Use **Refresh** if it seems stuck, or **Leave game** to exit.



The recap: podium, your placement, points and stations



Waiting for the others (Score mode)

TIP Playing as a team? Gather around one phone, or let every phone play at once: because everyone gets a different vault code and a different shuffled answer order, **nobody can simply copy a neighbor's screen**.

PART 2 · HOSTING A READY-MADE HUNT

The Hollow House

Every house keeps its secrets. This one has been waiting a long time to tell hers.

On All Hallows' Eve, the spirit of **Eleanor Hollow** stirs. A century ago she lived, and vanished, in a house just like yours. The town said she ran away. The truth was buried with her.

Tonight, your family and guests are the **mediums she has been waiting for**. Move through the house, wake her scattered memories, and gather the six numbers that open her father's old vault, all before midnight.

11	45–60	2–25	2
stations + a vault	minutes of play	players	tones: Family and Adult

One house, any house

The story never names a real floor plan. It casts **whatever space you are in** as the Hollow House. A one-bedroom apartment and a sprawling home both work: the entry, the living room, the kitchen, the bedroom, a dark corner and a high spot are mapped onto your own rooms, and the clues speak in the story's voice while pointing at your real space.

What to expect

- A **ghostly narrator** who reacts as you arrive at, and solve, every station.
- A **mix of puzzles**: ciphers, melodies, riddles, a portrait to study, a diary torn to pieces, and a final accusation.
- Objects that **appear in AR** exactly where the host placed them.
- A **Family version** that is spooky but warm, and an **Adult version** that is darker. Same puzzles, different voice.
- A **vault finale**. We won't say what's inside. Play to find out.

SPOILER-FREE This page deliberately tells you the setup only. Who did it, why, and how it ends are yours to discover.

PART 2 · HOSTING A READY-MADE HUNT

Getting a hunt: Store, purchase, account

The app is a **free download**. Ready-made hunts like The Hollow House are one-time in-app purchases, and the price you see in the Store is always the live App Store price for your country.

Step by step

1. **Open the Store tab.** Every ready-made hunt shows its title, a short description, stations, points, play time and player range.
2. **Tap a hunt card** for the full detail screen: complete description and a four-tile stat row.
3. **Tap "Buy for [price]."** Apple's purchase sheet appears. When it completes the button changes to **"You own this hunt"** and the Store card shows **Owned ✓**.
4. **Sign in with Apple** when you first tap **Host a hunt** on Home. This creates your host identity (one tap, no password to remember). Players never do this.
5. **Host a hunt** and pick your purchased hunt on the Host Setup screen (next page). It also appears under **My Hunts › Hunts you've purchased** for reference.

Ask to Buy / family sharing

If a parent approval is required you'll see **"Waiting for approval"** with a note that whoever approves purchases on your Apple ID has been asked (this is not an error). When they say yes, the hunt unlocks automatically.

New phone or reinstall?

Tap **Restore purchases**: it's in the Store header, on the buy screen, and in Profile. You'll see **Restored** or **Nothing to restore**.

PRICE SHOWS "UNAVAILABLE"? Check your connection and tap **Retry**. The Buy button stays disabled until the real price loads, so you never pay an unexpected amount.

What does a purchase include?

- The right to **host** that hunt as many times as you like, in any space.
- Every guest who joins plays **free**: no purchase, no account.
- All content, narration modes (Family and Adult) and the printable station-code pack.

NOTE There is no free demo or partial play of a ready-made hunt. Hosting needs the hunt purchase; playing as a guest needs nothing.

PART 2 · HOSTING

Host Setup: every option explained

Tap **Host a hunt** on Home. This one screen is where you prepare the whole game before anyone arrives.

1. **Which hunt.** Lists the ready-made hunts you own plus your own built hunts (if you've unlocked the Builder). Tap one to select it.
2. **Max players.** A stepper bounded by the hunt's range (Hollow House: 2–25). Latecomers can still join after the start, up to this number.
3. **"I'm hosting, not playing."** Turn on to run the game from a monitor screen without competing. You'll be marked **Host** and excluded from scores, standings and the winner.
4. **Timer.** On/off, with the length in minutes (pre-filled from the hunt, fully adjustable). The clock starts when you tap Start, and every phone shows the same time.
5. **Win mode. Race** or **Score**. See the table at right.
6. **Station codes**, **Place AR objects**, **Customize locations** and **Copy setup from my last game**: the four prep tools covered on the next pages.
7. Tap **Open the join lobby**. A room code is created and guests can join.

Choice	What happens
Race, no timer	First to finish wins; game ends at once.
Race + timer	First to finish wins. If time runs out first: **no winner**.
Score, no timer	Most points wins. Ends when all finish or you end it. Full points per station.
Score + timer	Most points wins when everyone finishes or time ends. Each station's points **decay** as the clock drains.

WHICH TO PICK? **Race** for kids' parties and quick drama. **Score** when you want careful thinkers to beat fast guessers. **Score + timer** for competitive adult groups.

REMEMBER Your choices apply only to *this game*. They never change the hunt itself.

Good to know

- **Everything starts fresh** each game. AR placements and "Proceed to" lines are per game; use **Copy setup from my last game** to bring them forward (page 14).
- If you have no purchases and no built hunts, Host Setup says **"Nothing to host yet"** and points you to the Store tab.
- Hosting a hunt you built needs the **Builder Unlock**. Hosting a bought hunt needs that hunt's purchase.

PART 2 · HOSTING

The station code print pack

Each station has one printed **QR card**. It does two jobs at once, which makes it the most important piece of paper in your game.

Job 1 · Proves arrival

Players scan it to confirm they are at the right station before the puzzle opens. A card for the wrong station is politely refused.

Job 2 · Anchors the AR object

The phone also uses the card as a **physical reference point**. Your AR object is saved as an offset from that card, so every player's phone shows it in **exactly the same real-world spot**.

How to get and print it

1. On **Host Setup** (or in the lobby) tap **Station codes**. You'll see how many markers need printing, for example "11 markers to print and place before guests arrive."
2. Tap the **share icon** at the top. The app builds a **multi-page PDF**: one station per US-Letter page with the station name, its clue and a large QR code.
3. In the share sheet choose **Print** (AirPrint), **Save to Files**, **AirDrop** or Messages.
4. **Print at "Actual Size" / 100%.** Never "Fit to Page."

WHY SIZE MATTERS Each QR code is designed to measure **8 cm (about 3.15 in)** wide. The AR system uses that size to work out where things are. Scaled-down prints still scan, but the object may float a little off its mark. Measure one code with a ruler after printing.

Using the printed pages

- **Cut or fold** each page so the code is easy to tape. The clue text on the page lets you stage the room without opening the app.
- **Use matte paper.** Glossy prints reflect light and fail to scan.
- Tape the card **flat** (no curl) on a firm surface.
- The codes are **static** for a given hunt and station. Print once and **reuse them every game**; re-print only if one is damaged.
- Keep the cards in station order in a folder for resetting later.
- You need the cards printed **before** you place AR objects (next page).

OPTIONS You can print everything, or only the stations you want. Single sheets? Pick pages in the Print dialog. No printer? Save the PDF and print at a library or office, or show a code on a second device (it should still be around 8 cm on screen).

PART 2 · HOSTING

Placing your AR objects

Placing means choosing the exact real-world spot where each station's hidden object appears. You do it once per game, with your own iPhone, before guests arrive. Budget about **1–2 minutes per station**.

Tape QR card on its spot › **Aim** camera at the card › **Move** object by tapping › **Size** pinch + twist › **Save** this spot

Step by step

1. **Tape up every QR card first,** exactly where it will stay. Don't move one after you place its object.
2. Host Setup (or the lobby) › **Place AR objects**. Each station with an AR object shows a status: **Placed ✓** or **Not yet**. The row on Host Setup reads, for example, "0 of 11 placed."
3. Tap a station. The camera opens. **Point it at that station's QR card** until the app recognizes it. The **Save** button stays disabled until the card has been seen, because the position is saved relative to the card.
4. The object appears on a surface the phone detects (tables, floors, walls). **Tap anywhere** to move it to that spot.
5. **Pinch** to make it bigger or smaller (about 0.4× to 3×) and **twist with two fingers** to turn it. Objects always stay upright. **Reset** returns it to the default.
6. Tap **Save this spot**. A toast confirms. Back out and the station now shows **Placed ✓**.

DO

- Place near the card, within arm's reach, so the card and object are in view together.
- Use rooms with good light and visible texture (rugs, shelves).
- Hide objects where a player can *walk up* and tap them.
- Test each one from a different angle.

AVOID

- Blank white walls and glossy or mirrored surfaces: the phone can't track them well.
- Moving the QR card after saving.
- Placing at the very last minute in a dark room.
- Setting up on someone else's device: AR needs **your** real iPhone.

IMPORTANT AR works only on a physical iPhone, never in a simulator. Your placements are private to *your* games: two hosts running the same hunt in their own homes never overwrite each other. Objects with a missing 3D model show as a simple colored placeholder shape.

PART 2 · HOSTING

Make it yours: "Proceed to" lines

A ready-made hunt's clues speak in the story's voice and stay generic ("descend to the place they hid what they feared"). **Customize locations** lets you add one short, plain line per station that tells players **where in your actual space** to go.

1. Host Setup (or lobby) › **Customize locations**.
2. For each station you see the original clue, **read-only**. The story text is never edited.
3. Type a **"Proceed to" line** (up to **60 characters**), or tap a suggested chip drawn from the hunt's place roles, such as the kitchen or the basement.
4. Players then see **Proceed to: your line** under the clue. It also prints under the station name on your QR cards.

EXAMPLE

Clue: "Mirrors don't lie, but they do reverse…"
Proceed to: Upstairs hall bathroom

Good "Proceed to" lines

- Name a room, not a puzzle: "Back deck," "Garage workbench."
- Match what guests would call it: "Grandma's den."
- Skip lines you want players to **figure out**; blank lines show nothing.
- Younger players? Be specific. Older players? Stay vague or leave blank.

Copy setup from my last game

Setting up 11 stations twice is no fun. On Host Setup, tap **Copy setup from my last game**. The app finds your **most recent game of this same hunt** (it looks through your last 10) that had any setup, and copies its **AR placements** and **"Proceed to" lines** into your new game. Nothing copies automatically: it only happens when you tap.

WHAT TO EXPECT

- Stations you already set up this time are **overwritten**; others are kept.
- Host Setup confirms what came over, for example "Copied from game FOX42: 6 AR placements, 3 custom clues."
- Works for ready-made hunts and for hunts you built.

ONLY IF AVAILABLE

- If you **deleted** the old game from Past hunts, its setup is gone too.
- Same room, cards and furniture? Great. A different venue? Re-place objects.

TIP Host in the same place every year (a Halloween tradition)? Don't delete your last game from Past hunts, and then it's a one-tap setup.

PART 2 · HOSTING

Family vs. Adult narration

One hunt, two voices. The puzzles and answers are identical; what changes is the **tone** of the clues, the narrator's lines and captions.

Family mode
Gentler language for younger players. Spooky but warm. Great for mixed ages, trick-or-treat parties and anyone who startles easily.

Adult mode
Darker, grimmer narration with more atmosphere. Best for adult game nights and teens who want a creepier edge.

How it works in the app

1. Every player has a small **Family mode · switch** pill on the clue screen. Tap it to flip to Adult, tap again to return.
2. **It is per phone, not per game.** A parent can play Adult while a child plays Family in the same game, side by side, with the same puzzles.
3. It changes: the **clue text**, the narrator's **arrival line** when you reach a station, the **solve line** after you finish it, the **on-screen captions**, and the **narration audio** if the hunt has recordings.
4. Your **Journal** re-reads in the current tone, so switching mid-game never leaves it half-and-half.
5. Nothing is lost. If a hunt has no Adult wording for a line, the Family line is used instead.

Two beats per station

Arrival line
The narrator's reaction when you scan the station code and arrive. It sets the mood and hints at what's here.

Solve line
The narrator's reaction after you solve the puzzle. It's logged to your Journal and often nudges you toward the next station.

HOSTING TIP Tell guests about the switch at the start. For a mixed group, suggest **Family mode for everyone under about 12**, and let others choose. The captions toggle (**CC**) and voice volume slider in the Journal help in loud rooms.

HUNTS YOU BUILD Family wording is required for each station; Adult wording is optional and easy to add. See page 24 for writing both.

PART 2 · HOSTING

The lobby: gather, then start

After **Open the join lobby** you land in the host lobby. This is your launch pad.

What you see

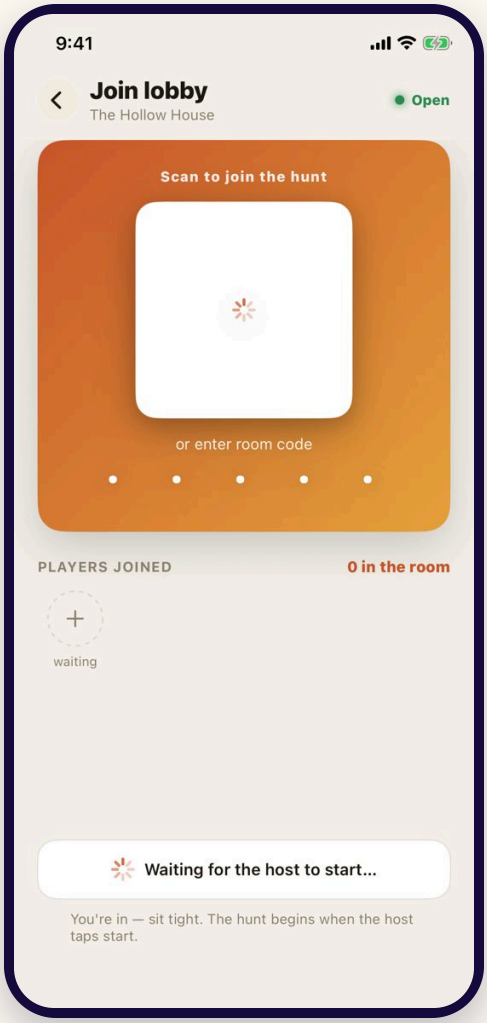
- A big **room code** (like FOX-42) and a **QR code** for guests to scan.
- A live **roster** that fills as players join, with their colored badges.
- Your **Start** button.
- Handy links: **View station codes**, **Place AR objects**, and a **Print join poster** link.

Print the join poster

Tap **"Need a join poster for the wall? Print it."** It creates a one-page black-and-white PDF with the hunt title, the join QR code and the room code in large type. Tape it by the entrance so guests can join without you.

Starting the game

1. Wait until everyone is in. (Latecomers can still join later.)
2. Tap **Start**. The button reads **"Starting…"** for a moment while the shared clock is set.
3. Every phone moves to the first clue at once. If you chose "hosting, not playing," you go to the monitor instead.



The player view of the lobby. The host's version also shows a Start button and large room code.

CAN'T START? If you see an error, tap **Retry**. To start a game with no players besides yourself, you need at least one *playing* player (a spectating host doesn't count).

PRE-GAME CHECKLIST

☐ QR cards printed at 100% and taped in place	☐ AR objects placed and Saved
☐ "Proceed to" lines added (optional)	☐ Phone fully charged and on Wi-Fi
☐ Win mode, timer and player limit chosen	☐ Guests have the free app installed

PART 2 · HOSTING

Running the game: monitor, end, rejoin

The Host Monitor

Your live control room. A **spectating host** goes straight to it when the game starts. A **playing host** opens it from the **Host view** link on the clue screen (and returns with the back arrow).

What it shows

- **Every player,** live: name, color, points.
- Progress such as **"4 of 11 stations"** and which station they are **on right now**.
- A **Finished** mark when someone completes the hunt.
- The **timer** (if on), the **win mode**, and the **room code**.
- **"X of Y finished"** across the whole group.
- Players are ranked: points, then stations done, then who finished earlier.

Why use it

- Spot a team that's stuck on one station and offer a hint.
- Judge when to wrap up a long game.
- Run a big party without playing: you're marked **Host** and never scored.

Leaving the monitor

Leave host view does *not* end the game. It keeps running for everyone else.

Ending a game early, for everyone

Only the host can do this, and only while the game is active. It works in **every** win mode.

1. Tap **End game** (on Standings, the monitor, the waiting screen, or the quiet link on the clue screen).
2. Confirm **"End the game for everyone?"**
3. The winner is whoever leads the standings (never a spectating host); with no players it closes with no winner. Every phone jumps to the **Recap**.

Coming back: rejoining and Past Hunts

Automatic

If the app closes or your phone restarts, reopening it reconnects you to the session you were in. The Home **Resume** card also returns you.

Deliberate: Profile › Past hunts

Lists every game you've hosted (lobby, active or finished) with date, status, winner and roster. Open one in **lobby or active** status and tap **Rejoin this hunt** to jump back in as host.

GAME CLEANUP In Past hunts, open a finished game and tap **Delete this past hunt**. It removes the session, its roster and its AR setup. Do this after a party you won't repeat, but keep the last game if you want one-tap **Copy setup** next time.

PART 3 · BUILDING YOUR OWN HUNT

The Hunt Builder, start to finish

Turn your own house, classroom, backyard or office into a story. The builder lives under **My Hunts**. You need **Sign in with Apple** and the one-time **Builder Unlock** purchase.

Create a hunt

1. **My Hunts › "+"** (Create a hunt). Sign in with Apple and unlock the Builder if asked.
2. **Hunt details: Title** (required), **Kicker** (a tagline like "A quick outdoor mystery") and **Description**.
3. **Theme.** Choose **Ghost** (spooky), **Pirate** or **Birthday**. The theme reskins the in-play screens: colors, type and the narrator persona. Optionally type your own **narrator name** to override the theme's.
4. Optionally turn on a **vault finale** and/or **randomize each player's station order** (page 23). Both sit above the stations.
5. **Add stations** with **+ Add station**. For each: a **name**, **clue text** (Family wording, plus optional Adult), a **puzzle type** and its settings, an optional **AR object**, optional **item reward**, optional **"requires holding"** gate, optional **narration**, and **points** (1–10,000; default 100).
6. Tap **Save hunt**. It stays disabled until the title, every station and any special setting is valid. After the first save, you can **Place your AR objects** and print **station codes**.

Edit, delete and test

- Tap any of your hunts in **My Hunts** to edit it ("Save changes"). The builder asks before discarding edits on Cancel.
- **Delete this hunt** (bottom, with a confirmation) also removes its uploaded files and your placements.
- **Test it yourself:** host it with Host Setup like any game. Play it solo in the same room; tap through each station from a second phone if you can.

Limits to know up front

Item	Limit
Puzzle types	All 11 are available at every station
Combination lock / dial code	3–8 digits / 1–8 digits
Multiple choice options · Observe hotspots · Logic grid	Up to 6 · up to 5 · 2–4 clues × 2–4 suspects
Vault finale	At least **2** stations must grant a digit
Themes	Ghost, Pirate, Birthday (the narrator name is editable)
Station arrival	Always by scanning the station's QR card
Editing ready-made hunts	Not possible: you can only edit your own

PART 3 · BUILDING

Your libraries and the 200 MB rule

Instead of re-creating the same candle or key for every hunt, you keep two personal **libraries** (under **My Hunts › My libraries**) and pull entries into any station.

AR Object library

Things that **appear in AR** at a station. Each entry has:

- a **name** and a starting **color** (10 choices)
- an optional **2D photo** (used as the picture in Observe puzzles)
- an optional **3D model** (**.usdz** file, picked from the Files app) that is what the AR camera actually shows

No model yet? The AR camera shows a simple colored shape in the entry's color: a fine placeholder.

Item library

Things players **collect** in the Satchel. Each entry has:

- a **name**
- an optional **description** (an inscription, flavor text or a hint)
- an optional **photo** for the Satchel tile

The same item can be granted at one station and required at another.

Using entries in a hunt

- In a station, the **AR object**, **Collectible reward** and **Requires holding** pickers list your library. Empty library? Tap **+ Add your first…** to jump there and back.
- When you **save the hunt**, the chosen entries and their files are **copied into that hunt** so guests can load them. Later library edits don't change saved hunts; re-save a hunt to pick them up.

Storage limits

What	Limit
Total storage per host	**200 MB** across all your files (photos, models, narration). A meter shows what you've used.
Entries per library	50 AR objects and 50 items
Each photo	2 MB. Photos are shrunk to 1280 px automatically.
Each 3D model (.usdz)	15 MB
Each narration clip (.mp3 or .m4a)	5 MB

HEADS UP A model used in several hunts is stored once per hunt *plus* once in your library. Big files add up faster than you expect.

MAKING ROOM Delete an old hunt (My Hunts › open it › **Delete this hunt**) or an unused library entry (My libraries). Deleting also removes the files. Keep 3D models small: 2–5 MB is plenty.

PART 3 · BUILDING

The 11 puzzle types at a glance

At each station choose a **Puzzle type**. Every puzzle also has a **prompt** the player reads on screen. Difficulty labels are the app's own.

Type	Level	How it plays	You set up
Riddle / text	Easy	Player types a free-text answer.	The answer, plus an "Also accept" list (one per line).
Combination Lock	Easy	Player enters a numeric code on a keypad.	A 3–8 digit code.
Dial / set the value	Hard	Same as the lock, shown as a single dial.	A 1–8 digit value.
Cipher wheel	Hard	Player decodes ciphertext shown in the prompt, then types it.	The coded text in the prompt and the real answer.
Tap the sequence	Med	Player taps items in the right order. Shuffled per player and never shown in solve order.	2+ steps in the correct order.
Drag to reorder	Med	Player drags strips until the order is right.	2+ pieces in the correct order.
Multiple choice	Hard	Player picks one answer. Options are shuffled per player.	2–6 options; tap one as correct.
QR verify	Easy	Player scans the station's QR code, reads your prompt, taps Continue.	Nothing but the prompt.
Physical prop + AR	Med	Player finds a real object and follows your prompt (read a card, open a box, remember a number).	The prompt. Add an AR object for a reveal.
Tap to find (Observe)	Easy	Player taps the correct spot on a picture.	A picture (chosen in the puzzle setup), then tap to place up to 5 hotspots; mark the right one.
Logic grid	Hard	Player marks clues against suspects, then names one.	2–4 clues, 2–4 suspects, the true matches, the culprit.

GOOD TO KNOW Riddle and cipher answers ignore capital letters and extra spaces at the ends, but not wording: add alternates like "a clock" and "clock" under **Also accept**. On **Observe**, tap the picture preview to drop each hotspot, label it, and tap its circle to mark the correct one. **Observe picture:** use **Choose picture from Photos** in the puzzle setup. It uploads when you tap Save. With no picture chosen, the station's AR object picture is used, else a placeholder. Change the picture later? Re-check your hotspots: they stay at the same spots.

NO PUZZLE? A station can have no puzzle at all: players just acknowledge it and move on. Good for story beats and "walk here" stops.

PART 3 · BUILDING

Sample puzzles, and when to use each

Copy any sample as-is, or swap in your own house details. **Use when** notes tell you why you'd pick one type over another.

Riddle / text · Easy

Prompt: "I have hands but cannot clap, and a face but cannot smile. Find me and tell me what I am."
Answer: clock · **Also accept:** a clock, the clock
Use when: you want a classic, warm-up puzzle with a one-word answer. Add alternate answers so a "the" or "a" never blocks a correct guess.

Combination Lock · Easy

Prompt: "The toolbox has a four-digit lock. Count the windows on the front of the house, the steps to the porch, the chairs at the table… the card in the shed lists the order."
Code: 4172
Use when: the answer is a number found by exploring. It pairs beautifully with a printed card the player must find.

Dial / set the value · Hard

Prompt: "Half of the number of legs on the kitchen table and its four chairs. Set the dial."
Value: 10 · *(table 4 + chairs 16 = 20; half = 10)*
Use when: you want a single number with a tiny bit of arithmetic. Same mechanic as the lock; choose it for the "dial" feel.

Cipher wheel · Hard

Prompt: "The note reads IBVOUFE. Shift each letter back by one, then tell me what haunts this house."
Answer: haunted
Use when: you want players to *decode* something. Put the key (shift by one) in the prompt, or hide it on a card for a harder game.

Tap the sequence · Medium

Prompt: "Light the candles in the order of the rainbow shown on the hall poster."
Steps, in order: Red · Orange · Yellow · Green · Blue · Purple
Use when: there's an order to *observe* in the room. Players see the buttons shuffled differently from everyone else, so there's no copying.

PART 3 · BUILDING

Sample puzzles, continued

Drag to reorder · Medium

Prompt: "A torn letter was left behind. Drag the strips until it reads true."
Pieces, in order: "Dear Sam," · "The treasure is not where you think." · "Look where the sunshine ends."

Use when: the answer is a sentence or story that makes sense only one way. Players solve by *reading*, so it needs no outside knowledge.

Multiple choice · Hard

Prompt: "Which of these did the captain NOT take on the voyage?"
Options: a brass compass · a silver spoon · **a parrot named Mabel** (correct) · a rolled map

Use when: you want to test whether players *paid attention* to the story or earlier clues. Order is shuffled per player.

QR verify · Easy

Prompt: "A second code is taped inside the pantry door. Scan it, then read what the shelf label says."

Use when: you want players to go somewhere *extra* or need proof they physically did a step.

Physical prop + AR · Medium

Prompt: "Open the red tin on the shelf. The number on the card inside is your next clue. Remember it, then tap Continue."

Use when: you have real objects to hide. The information found carries to a later lock or riddle. Add an AR object for a spooky reveal.

Tap to find (Observe) · Easy

Photo: a picture of your living-room mantel. **Hotspots:** candlestick · family photo · **a muddy footprint** (correct) · vase
Prompt: "Someone walked through here after dark. What gives them away?"

Use when: you want players to *look carefully* at a scene. Take a clear, well-lit photo of the real place.

Logic grid · Hard

Clues: "Flour on the shoes" · "A chocolate-stained napkin" **Suspects:** The baker · The butler · The cat · The guest
Matches: flour→baker; napkin→baker. **Culprit:** The baker

Use when: you want a finale-style "name the culprit" moment. Keep clues to 2–4 so the grid stays readable on a phone.

PART 3 · BUILDING

Items, gates, vaults and shuffles

Four optional power-ups that turn a list of stations into a proper adventure.

1 · Item rewards

Pick a **Collectible reward** at a station and players get that item in their Satchel when they solve it. The same item can be given at several stations; a player still holds just one copy.

2 · "Requires holding" gates

Pick an item the player must already hold before the puzzle accepts a correct answer, such as "needs the Rusty Key." A banner on the puzzle screen explains why. A soft warning appears if no *earlier* station grants that item, so you can't accidentally trap players.

3 · Vault finale

Turn on **End with a vault finale**, then tick **Grants a vault digit** on at least **2** stations. Each player gets their **own** random code, built from digits earned at those stations. After the last station, they enter the digits (any order) to open the vault and finish.

4 · Randomize station order

Each player starts at a different station and works around the loop, wrapping at the end, so a crowd isn't all queued at the same spot. The story still plays fully.

CAN'T COMBINE **Randomize station order** and **"Requires holding"** gates are mutually exclusive: a rotated player could reach a gated station before the one that grants the key. The builder blocks Save until you remove one.

Points and scoring

Each station awards **1–10,000 points** (default 100). In **Score** mode *with* a timer the number is the **most** a player can earn at that station and it shrinks steadily toward zero as the clock runs out; otherwise it is awarded in full. Harder or farther stations deserve more points.

Test before the party

1. Save the hunt, then **Place your AR objects** and print the station codes.
2. Host a game from Host Setup. Play it start to finish on one phone while a friend watches the **monitor**.
3. Switch Family and Adult tones mid-game and read each line aloud.
4. Fix anything with a quick edit: open the hunt in **My Hunts**, change it and **Save changes**. Start a new game to see updates.

TIP Updating the hunt after guests have joined? Changes apply to games started *afterward*. Always finish the current party first.

PART 3 · BUILDING

Writing narration that makes sense

Open a station's **Narration (optional)** section. You get four boxes. Only the first is required, and if you leave it blank the app writes a plain "You've reached…" line for you.

Box	When players hear it	What it should do
Arrival (Family)	Right after they scan this station's code	Set the mood, name the place, tease the puzzle
Arrival (Adult)	Same moment, Adult mode	Same facts, darker or wittier voice
Solve (Family)	Right after they solve it	React, reveal a story beat, point onward
Solve (Adult)	Same moment, Adult mode	Same beat, sharper edge

- **Adult blank?** Players in Adult mode hear the Family line.
- **Solve blank?** The arrival line is reused.
- Add **audio** for any filled box: an MP3 or M4A up to 5 MB, picked from the Files app (a Voice Memos recording works). No audio? Captions still show.
- Keep each line to **1–3 short sentences**: players are mid-game.

A worked example: "The Pirate's Map Room"

1 Station 1 · The Dock (QR + keypad)

ARRIVAL · FAMILY
"Ahoy, mateys! You've found the old dock. The captain left a chest here. Can you crack its four numbers?"

SOLVE · FAMILY
"Click! The chest is open. Inside, a torn map piece… it points to the ship's galley. Go!"

ARRIVAL · ADULT
"The dock. Salt and rot. He hid his first secret here, the greedy old fool."

2 Station 2 · The Galley (physical prop + AR)

ARRIVAL · FAMILY
"The galley! Cook always kept his rum cake recipe locked up. There's a red tin on the shelf: open it."

SOLVE · FAMILY
"Aha, a number on a card! Remember it: the captain's wheel will want it."

What each line should (and shouldn't) do

DO

- Name the *place* on arrival so the story matches the room.
- On solve, give a **reward feeling** plus a **breadcrumb** to the next station.
- Keep the narrator's personality steady.

AVOID

- Giving away the answer in the arrival line.
- Referring to things players haven't seen yet.
- Long paragraphs: they won't be read mid-hunt.

PART 4 · TIPS AND TRICKS

Setting up like a pro

Plan the route

- **Walk the route** before you print anything. Aim for a loop that never sends everyone through the same hallway at once.
- Spread stations across **different rooms** and levels. For small spaces, put two stations in one room but at different spots (a shelf, then a window).
- Keep stations **1–3 minutes apart on foot**. A hunt of 10–11 stations should take about 45–60 minutes.
- Make **Station 1 easy and close to the start**: it teaches the scan-and-tap rhythm.

Card placement

- **Eye level or lower** (about 3–5 feet) so kids and adults can both scan.
- Use **painter's tape** or removable putty: no residue.
- Put cards on **flat, steady** surfaces: a wall, a door, a table edge.
- Avoid mirrors, windows and shiny glass behind the card.
- Don't put a card where it can be **knocked or bumped**.
- Number the back of each card lightly in pencil ("S4") for fast resetting.
- Keep one card **per spot** unless a puzzle intentionally reuses it.
- Hide, don't bury: players need to find it by reading the clue.

AR placement tricks

- Place objects **after** the cards are up, in the same lighting guests will have.
- Choose spots with **texture and good light**. Place objects at a **comfortable tap height**, not on the floor behind furniture.
- Make objects **larger** than you think: pinching to 1.5–2× helps in big rooms.
- Re-check one or two stations on a **second phone** before the party.

Storage and cleanup

- Watch the **storage meter** (200 MB per host). Delete old tests early.
- After the party: peel cards, keep the PDFs for next time, and in **Profile › Past hunts** delete games you won't reuse.
- Account deletion in **Profile** removes your hunts, files and hosted games (it can't remove your name from *other* hosts' games).

PARTY-DAY ORDER Charge phones · print/tape cards · place and save AR objects · add Proceed-to lines · open the lobby · put the join poster on the wall · let guests install the app · start.

PART 4 · TIPS AND TRICKS

Writing clues players will love

A station has **two jobs**: a **navigation clue** that sends players to the right spot, and a **puzzle** they solve once they get there. Keep the two separate.

Navigation clue
Answers "**where**?" It should have **exactly one correct answer** in your space. Test it by asking someone new.

Puzzle prompt
Answers "**what** do I do here?" It should reference something real at the spot, so the card and the object matter.

Five tips for navigation clues

1. **Point to one feature.** "Where the family keeps its warmth" (fireplace) beats "a room downstairs."
2. **Use feelings and function** ("where meals are made") rather than the object's name: it feels like a riddle but stays solvable.
3. **Match the age group.** For kids, use colors and sizes ("the big blue chair"). For adults, wordplay and allusion.
4. **Add a "Proceed to" line** (page 14) as a safety net, so nobody is lost for 10 minutes.
5. **Chain clues.** Let a number or word learned at one station become the answer at the next. It rewards the Satchel and Journal.

Five tips for puzzle prompts

1. **One idea per puzzle.** Don't ask for a cipher *and* a count in the same station.
2. **Make the answer findable** in the room, on a card or in the story, never only in your head.
3. **Give the format** ("a four-digit code," "one word") so players type the right thing.
4. **Vary the types** from station to station: mix thinking puzzles with moving-around ones.
5. **Rise in difficulty.** Easy start, harder middle, a satisfying finale.

Pairing puzzle type with purpose

If you want players to…	Use
Look closely at a scene	Tap to find
Walk to a second spot or prove presence	QR verify
Use real hidden objects	Physical prop + AR
Decode or calculate	Cipher, Riddle, Dial, Combination Lock
Put a story or process in order	Drag to reorder, Tap the sequence
Remember the story so far	Multiple choice, Logic grid

PART 4 · TIPS AND TRICKS

Game ideas to steal

Each idea lists a suggested theme, group, length and which puzzle types carry it.

The Birthday Heist

Birthday theme · kids 6–10 · 8 stations

The party hat has been stolen! Follow the sprinkle trail. Finish with a **Combination Lock** on the "cake chest."

Types: Tap to find, Tap the sequence (candle colors), Riddle, Physical prop.

Pirate Treasure Map

Pirate theme · all ages · 6–10 stations

Piece together a torn map, find the captain's key and open the treasure.

Types: Drag to reorder (map pieces), Dial (compass), Cipher (captain's code), vault finale.

Escape the Office

Ghost theme · adults · 6 stations

A team-building hunt: whodunit in the break room. Use **Score + timer** so speed counts.

Types: Logic grid, Multiple choice, QR verify, Combination Lock.

Haunted Halloween Hunt

Ghost theme · family · 8–11 stations

Use **Family** for the young ones and let teens flip to **Adult**. Finish with a **vault finale**.

Types: Cipher, Observe (portrait), Sequence, vault.

Backyard Nature Quest

Any theme · toddlers–6 · 5 stations

Easy puzzles and big colors. A parent hosts as a **spectator** and watches the monitor.

Types: Tap to find, QR verify, Physical prop.

Family Reunion Mystery

Birthday/Ghost theme · mixed · 10 stations

Puzzles are family trivia ("Which uncle owned the red truck?"). Use **Multiple choice** heavily and a **Logic grid** finale.

Themes in one line each

- **Ghost** — mystery, midnight palette, spooky narrator persona (Eleanor Hollow by default).
- **Pirate** — swashbuckling; Bosun Grimjaw narrates by default.
- **Birthday** — bright and cheery; Captain Sprinkles narrates by default.
- Type your own **narrator name** to rename the voice, and the initials change with it.

SEASONAL REMIX Keep a base hunt and re-skin it: change the story in the narration boxes and AR objects, keep the proven puzzles and cards. Re-host every holiday with a one-tap **Copy setup**.

PART 4 · HELP

Troubleshooting and FAQ

Problem	Try this
QR card won't scan	Step back so the whole code is in view, add light, make sure the card isn't glossy or curled. Check camera permission in Settings › BuscAR Hunt.
"That's not a station marker"	You scanned something else. Use the card at the station named in your clue.
AR object doesn't appear	Keep the station card in view and move slowly. The top pill reads "Find the marker" until the card is seen. Check lighting. Confirm the host saved this station.
Object is in a slightly different place	The card was moved, or printed smaller than 8 cm. Reprint at 100% and ask the host to re-place the object.
"This room is full"	The host's player limit is reached. Ask them to raise it next game.
Join code not working	Codes are 3 letters + 2 numbers. Check you're on the same game, and the host has opened the lobby. Try scanning the QR.
Timer doesn't match someone's phone	It's driven by the host's shared clock; wait a few seconds or reconnect.
Stuck on a puzzle	Check your Journal and Satchel. Ask the host to read the monitor and give a nudge.
Hunt won't load	"Couldn't load this hunt": check connection and tap **Try Again**, or **Leave hunt**.
Price shows "unavailable"	Check your connection and tap **Retry**. Hunts can be restored for free with **Restore purchases**.
Upload failed (builder)	Check size limits (photo 2 MB, model 15 MB, audio 5 MB, 200 MB total). Free space with **Delete this hunt** or library clean-up.

Quick answers

Do guests need an account?

No. Joining and playing is free and anonymous.

Can I play without a camera?

You can type the room code. Stations need scanning for arrival.

Does it work offline?

No. Games sync live, so everyone needs a connection.

Can I delete my account?

Profile › Delete account after a fresh Sign in with Apple. Purchases stay with your Apple ID.

SIGN OUT In Profile, **Sign out** (Apple accounts) returns you to a guest identity. Sign in with Apple again to get your hunts back.



Quick reference

Player cheat sheet

1. Home › Join a hunt
2. Scan the QR or type the code
3. Read the clue; walk there
4. Scan the station card
5. Tap the AR object
6. Solve; watch the Satchel
7. Enter your own vault code

Host cheat sheet

1. Buy the hunt (Store)
2. Sign in with Apple
3. Host a hunt › pick options
4. Print cards at 100%; tape up
5. Place and Save AR objects
6. Add Proceed-to lines
7. Open lobby › Start › Monitor

Builder cheat sheet

My Hunts › + · Title, theme, stations · pick puzzle types · fill libraries · optional vault/gate/shuffle · **Save hunt** · Place AR objects · print codes · host it · test it · refine.

Need help?

bondtk@gmail.com · https://bondtk.github.io/contact.html
Include your room code and iPhone model if you reach out.

Thank you for playing. Now go make some memories.

BuscAR Hunt · Official Guide · © 2026 Troy Bond